

The Australian Fishing Zone (AFZ) was first declared in 1979. It covers Commonwealth waters—generally from 3 nautical miles to 200 nautical miles from the Australian coast. The AFZ is established through the Fisheries Management Act 1991. It relates only to the use or protection of Commonwealth fisheries. The AFZ covers an area of over 8 million square kilometres.

As a matter of Australian domestic law, the [Offshore Constitutional Settlement](#) provides for the Australian states and the Northern Territory to manage fisheries out to 3 nautical miles from the coast, and for the Australian Government to manage fisheries from 3 to 200 nautical miles. However, these default arrangements are frequently varied through instruments known as offshore constitutional settlement arrangements.

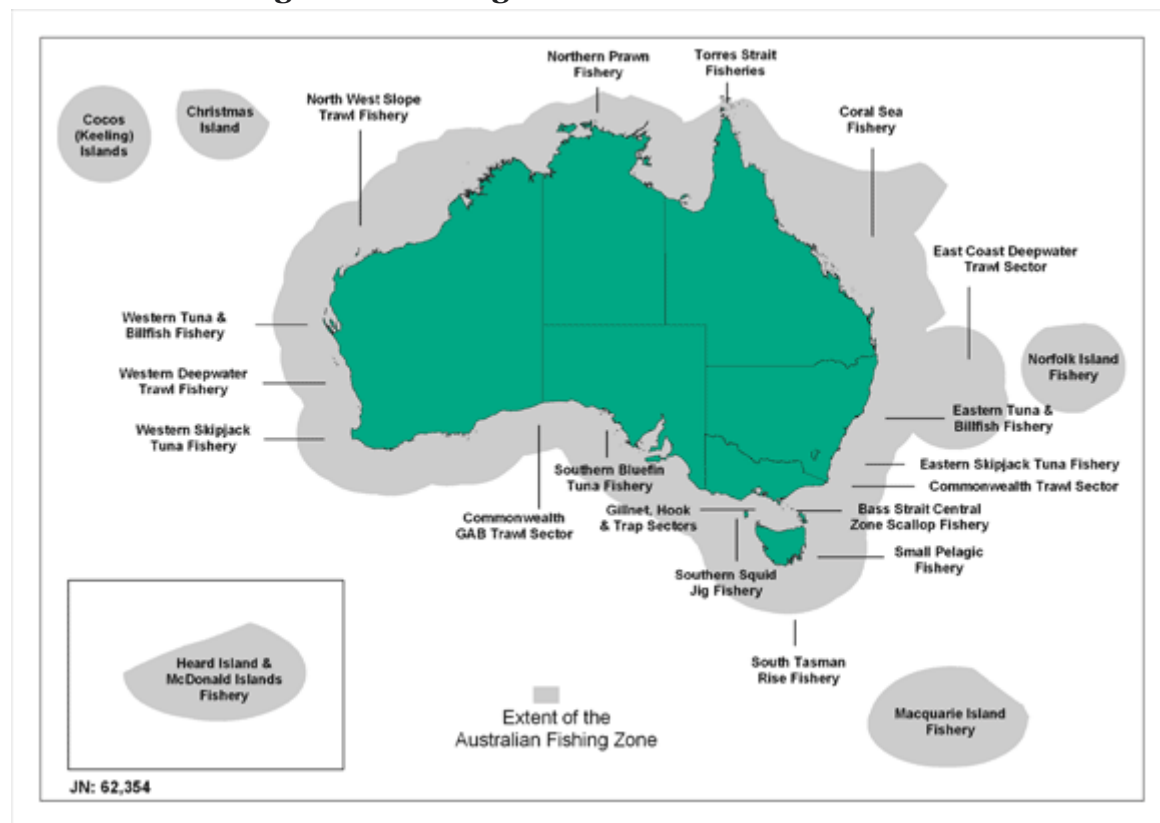
Australia's territorial sea extends from the coast out to 12 nautical miles. Australia has full sovereignty within the territorial sea, including with respect to fisheries.

Australia's Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) extends from 12 nautical miles to 200 nautical miles from its coastline. Within its EEZ, Australia has sovereign rights to explore, use, conserve and manage its natural resources, including fish, oil, gas and minerals. It also has jurisdiction over offshore installations, marine scientific research and the protection and preservation of the marine environment.

Consistent with international law, Australia has also claimed sovereign rights to explore and exploit the natural resources of the continental shelf (including sedentary species) where the shelf extends beyond 200 nautical miles.

[Geoscience Australia's website contains](#) further information about the Australian maritime zones.

Australian Fishing Zone showing the location of Commonwealth fisheries



Map Courtesy of the Australian Fisheries Management Authority, 2008

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/fisheries/domestic/zone>